

A Debt Called In, A Country Erased

Lesson 31 — The Gulf War, 1990–91

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain how Iraq's Iran-Iraq War debt directly shaped its decision to invade Kuwait

2

Describe the coalition's build-up and the two-phase military campaign that followed

3

Explain why the coalition stopped short of removing Saddam Hussein from power

4

Evaluate how decisively this war actually resolved the tensions that caused it

A debt that would not simply disappear

Lesson 30 ended with Iraq owing an estimated \$37–40 billion to Gulf creditors after eight years of war. This lesson covers exactly how that debt, and Saddam's response to it, led directly to his next, far more consequential war.

Debt, oil prices, and a disputed field

Saddam demanded Kuwait and the UAE cancel Iraq's war debt, arguing the loans should count as payment for protecting the Gulf from Iranian expansion; both refused. He further accused Kuwait of exceeding OPEC production quotas to depress oil prices, and of stealing oil via slant-drilling from the shared Rumaila field — while also demanding Kuwait cede the Bubiyan and Warbah islands.

Ambiguity, on the eve of invasion

In a July 1990 meeting, US Ambassador April Glaspie's response to Saddam's grievances was widely read afterward as insufficiently firm, feeding his apparent belief that Washington would not intervene militarily over a regional Arab dispute. Egyptian President Hosni Mubarak's attempt to mediate talks between Iraq and Kuwait collapsed within two hours.

2 August 1990

Around 100,000 Iraqi troops overran Kuwait within hours, seizing the capital, key airfields, and the royal palaces; Kuwait's royal family escaped to Saudi Arabia. The UN Security Council condemned the invasion immediately under Resolution 660, and two-thirds of the Arab League's members joined the condemnation — a miscalculation of regional and international reaction on Saddam's part.

Operation Desert Shield

Led by the United States, a coalition of some 35 nations assembled the largest military deployment since the Second World War — eventually roughly 750,000 troops, including some 540,000 Americans, against an Iraqi occupation force of similar scale. On 29 November 1990, the UN Security Council authorised “all necessary means” against Iraq if it had not withdrawn by 15 January 1991.

Operation Desert Storm begins

From 17 January 1991, coalition aircraft flew tens of thousands of sorties against Iraqi air defences, command infrastructure, and military targets, using new precision-guided munitions alongside conventional bombing. Iraq fired Scud missiles at Israel, hoping to provoke retaliation that would fracture Arab support for the coalition — the United States successfully pressed Israel not to respond.

Burning oil, and a poisoned Gulf

As defeat became likely, Iraqi forces set fire to roughly 600–700 Kuwaiti oil wells and deliberately released oil into the Persian Gulf — a scorched-earth tactic causing severe, lasting environmental damage well beyond any conventional military objective.

One hundred hours

Operation Desert Sabre, the coalition ground offensive, began on 24 February 1991 and achieved a decisive victory within roughly one hundred hours — liberating Kuwait entirely and advancing into southern Iraq before President Bush declared a ceasefire on 28 February.

The war, by the numbers

~390

Coalition military deaths

**20,000–
35,000**

Estimated Iraqi military deaths

100 hours

Duration of the decisive ground campaign

Roughly 100,000 Iraqi soldiers were taken prisoner; over 3,000 Iraqi civilians were killed in coalition air strikes.

Why the coalition stopped at Iraq's border

The coalition's mandate, under UN resolutions, was to liberate Kuwait — not to overthrow Saddam Hussein's government. Roughly half of his Republican Guard escaped the ceasefire's terms, remaining intact enough to brutally suppress Shia uprisings in Basra and Kurdish uprisings in the north within weeks, while the international coalition that had just defeated his army did not intervene.

A full essay attempt

'The coalition's decision to leave Saddam Hussein in power in 1991 should be judged a serious strategic mistake.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence about the ceasefire's terms and the uprisings that followed
- Address the counter-argument that the coalition's mandate was legally and politically limited to Kuwait alone

Key terms from today

Operation Desert Shield

The coalition's military build-up phase, August 1990–January 1991.

UN Resolution 678

Authorised 'all necessary means' against Iraq from January 1991.

Operation Desert Storm

The air and ground campaign, January–February 1991.

Scorched-earth tactics

Deliberate destruction, such as burning oil wells, beyond military necessity.

What to remember

Iraq's crushing war debt and oil disputes with Kuwait led directly to its 1990 invasion, met by an unprecedented international coalition that liberated Kuwait within a hundred-hour ground campaign after five weeks of bombardment. The coalition's deliberate decision to stop short of Baghdad left Saddam in power, and his surviving Republican Guard, to crush uprisings the war itself had encouraged.

Lesson 32 — Closing Block B5: essay practice

Next lesson closes this block with focused essay practice across Gulf politics and conflict, before Block B6 turns to the Middle East's peace processes, political Islam, and the road to the 2003 Iraq War.